Bills would provide more financial aid to California college students

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More relief for the heavy costs of college - fees, books, food and housing - could become available for California students under two bills introduced Thursday in the state Legislature.

Senate Bill 291 would set up a new financial aid program specifically for community college students that would take into account the total cost of college attendance, not just school fees, when calculating the size of each students' grant.

"The true cost of attending college is clearly more than just tuition," said Sen. Connie Leyva, D-Chino (San Bernardino County), who introduced the bill co-authored by eight Democrats, including two from San Francisco — Sen. Scott Wiener and Assemblyman David Chiu — and Assemblywoman Buffy Wicks of Oakland.

"When non-tuition costs like housing, food and textbooks are considered, community college is often more expensive for our lowest-income students to attend than other state universities," Leyva said, reflecting a 2017 study by the Institute for College Access & Success, an Oakland nonprofit.

Eloy Ortiz Oakley, chancellor of the state's community college system, said he favors the bill because so few community college students receive financial aid for expenses beyond college fees.

Although the reasons aren't clear, just 5 percent of community college students received a Cal Grant last year, compared with 39 percent of undergraduates at the University of California, and about 36 percent at California State University, according to Oakley's office.

Assembly Bill 542 would add 3,000 additional grants to the Competitive Cal Grant program for low-income students, which turns away thousands of qualified students, according to a statement by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Van Nuys, who introduced the bill.

"For my family and so many others, California's public higher education system was a ticket into the middle class," Gabriel said in a statement. "We must ensure that our young people have access to the education they need to secure good jobs."

Neither bill specifies how much the Legislature would need to appropriate to fund the additional grants.

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